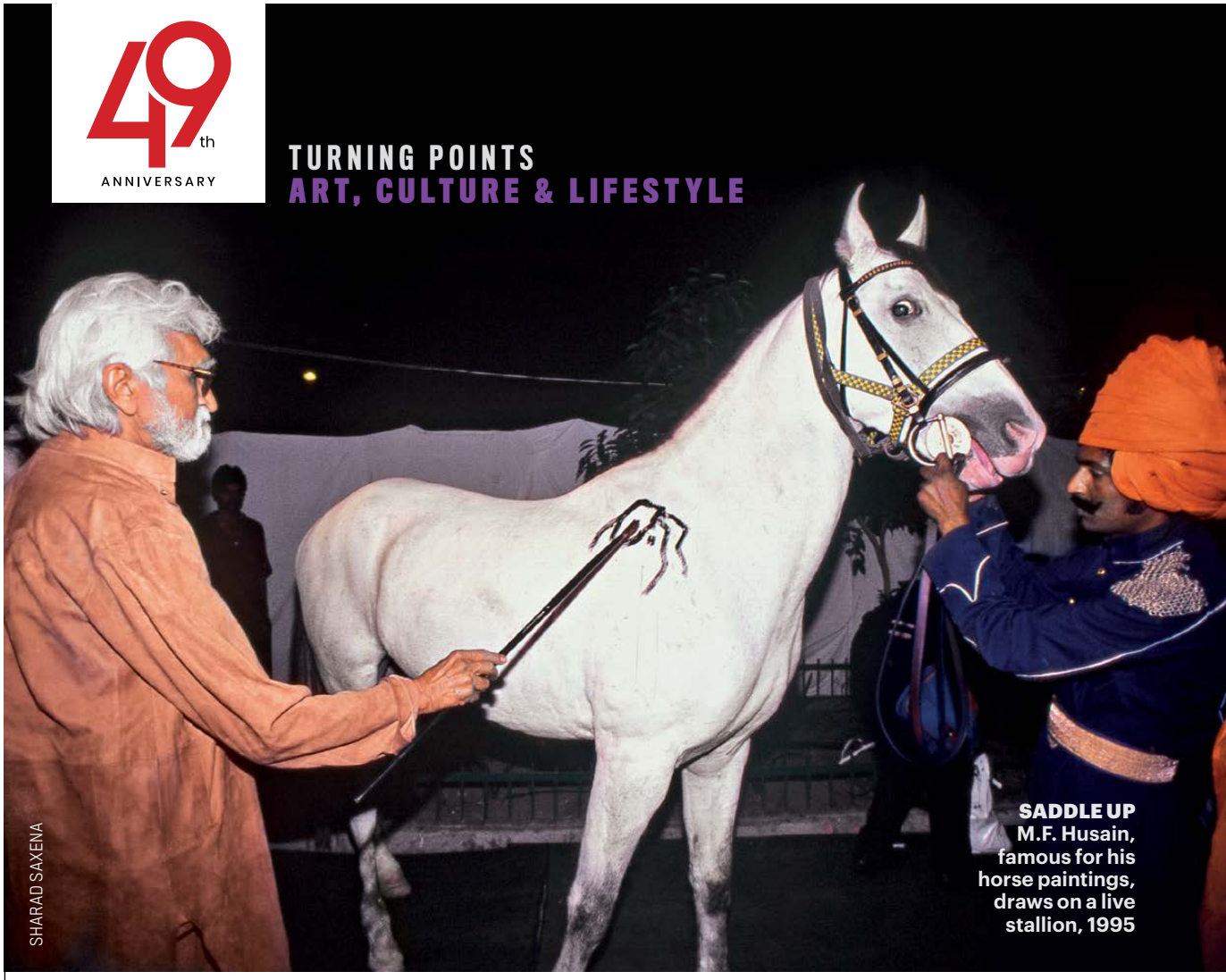


SHARAD SAXENA

SADDLE UP M.F. Husain, famous for his horse paintings, draws on a live stallion, 1995

INDIAN ART

A BRUSH WITH GOLD DUST

The 1990s economic liberalisation came as oxygen, lighting up the Indian art scene. Today, artworks by established masters routinely go for astronomical amounts

BY KAI FRIESE

The alchemy of capitalism and art is all too familiar today—as anyone who has watched videos of crypto currency billionaire Justin Sun eating Maurizio Cattelan's duct-taped banana knows. Sun had paid an honest $6.2 million (around Rs 50 crore) for the privilege, at a Sotheby's auction, of course. While Indian artists have not yet achieved quite this level of *succès de scandale*, artworks by a number of our leading modernist painters, particularly dead ones, are routinely auctioned at prices to rival that vanishing banana.

Indian contemporary art had lived in the abstract shadows of western masters for much of the 20th century, with home-grown talents like M.F. Husain and F.N. Souza locked in a sullen contest for recognition as 'India's Picasso'. All that changed, like much else, in the wake of the economic liberalisation of the 1990s. The milestone year of 1995 saw two auctions of modern Indian art, at Sotheby's in New York and Christie's in London, heralding an escalation